Troll and Dear Invisible Men

By Shane Koyczan and Musa Okwonga

INTRODUCTION

Before the digital age, bullies occupied playgrounds, classrooms and walks home after school. Today, the internet has created new places for 'trolls' to hide.

This poem by Shane Koyczan takes a poignant looks at the pain caused by online bullies – also known as 'trolls.' These digital trolls hide behind anonymous usernames on sites such as YouTube or Instagram, insulting random people and urging suicidal kids to kill themselves.

Troll by Shane Koyczan

Troll

Once upon a time, you and all your kind
lived underneath bridges
had ridges for ribs that dropped off into empty
    chests
as if your hearts were all stolen treasures
as if an excavation crew were hired to dig up and
    remove the part of you that let you feel
and while the world above you invented the wheel

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    you stayed put
knowing that would one day roll over top of you to
    get to where it's going
you had an endlessly flowing supply line of food
you began to brood over humanity and made meals
    of our hope
as if crushing our spirits would make your mirrors
    cast better reflections than the ones they gave
as if the only way you could save yourselves was to make
the world ugly so no one would notice you
    hided in it
you learned to knit pain into a kind of camouflage
treated hope like a mirage that you could use to
    lure in your next meal
you lived off our fears, you could taste what we
    feared
and every night, as the moon at bedtime stories on
    sunlight
you took darkness as an invite to head out into the
    woods
you curled your hands into wrecking balls

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your breath became squalls, you made rocks rumble,
you made land shiver, you made boys and girls pray that someone would deliver them from you
we told them, you aren't real
and then one day, the world changed
but you all stayed the same
just migrated from living underneath bridges to living underneath information superhighways
days and nights became meaningless, each already deep in chest became an abyss no one would ever find the bottom of
concepts like love fell into your gravity
we turned ourselves into life preservers hoping to save as many as we could
but the fathers who guarded closet doors and the mothers who secured the floors under
beds all shook their heads not knowing how to deal with you
you, who crept into our lives, with tongues like knifes stabbing your words into our skin
you began to begin uploading yourselves into our homes

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you had computer screens for eyes and software for bones
you turned your hate into stones
and hurled them at beauty, as if you couldn't bear to see anything other than ugly
anything different
you had fingernails like flint and scraped them against decency hoping we would be the
ones to all catch fire
you all had smiles like one-way barbed wire not meant to keep us out, but to keep us in
always like a firing pin, you spoke in explosions
it isn't cute
it isn't funny
you talked strangers into death
and laughed
and as each family learns to graft skin over the wounds you gave them, you helm yourself
into the scar
you have coaxed the sober back into bars, handed out cigars at memorials

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offered nooses, cliffs, and pills to those who
unfortunately found you before they found
help
you praised suffering
waltzed in between tragedies, gracefully dipping
miseries as if we would be somehow
impressed by the dexterity of your animosity
you cheered on rape
dashed through police tape as if it were the finish line in
a race on who could be awful
first
even now
you somehow see this as an invitation to turn your
keyboards into catapults
wondering which one of you can be the first to hate us
best
your loathing
already dressed in riot gear
ready to incite rage
as if each message board is a stage who you recite
hostility turning freedom of speech

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into freedom of cruelty
we are stuck with you
the same way you are stuck with you
your mind is glue and it keeps malice fastened there like
cheap wallpaper
we were once upon a time told that none of you exist
we dismissed you as make believe or myth, now
on only with resolve
we can no longer afford to tell ourselves, that you aren't
real
we will not let you make your dinners out of the things
we feel.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Shane Koyczan
Book: Silence is a Song I Know all the Words To
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Book can be purchased from the author's website at
https://www.shanekoyczan.com/merch-store

TRANSITION

For people (particularly women) who suffer abuse online at the hands of trolls, this next poem raises some interesting and reassuring points. While trolls can cause a lot of pain by failing to recognize the real humans they are insulting, it can be easy when you're under attack to forget that the trolls are real humans too. Humans with enough fear and emptiness in their lives to drive them to set up these anonymous accounts in the first place. Dear Invisible Men by Musa Okwonga.

Dear Invisible Men

Dear invisible men,

Who tweet women endless threats of rape,

Who are you?

Are you married fathers of two?

Are you teens crowded round a friend's phone in a canteen or KFC?

Are you pausing between texting your first love,

To set yourself up as an egg,

And post fresh hate?

Where are you as you type this?

Is your girlfriend asleep in your arms,

As you peer over her shoulder at your phone?

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How did this become your sport?

You are not proud of what you do;

If you were, you would not care who knew.

This is strange:

You loudly announce pride in your prejudice

But your invisibility suggests your shame.

There is such an anger in you

That it cannot be cloaked with jokes.

I pity the mirror that has to reflect your misery,

Since it must see so much.

Because the women are everywhere now,

Aren't they?

They weren't just content in your beds,

Now they're not just in your clubs,

Or in the eyes and hearts of other men;

The women are in your classrooms, boardrooms and DJ booths,

They are obstructing you, or ignoring you,

Not needing you to improve.

Swiftly, they are sweeping you from every stage,

And the only place you feel safe

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Is in one-hundred and forty characters of rage.

I doubt that, as you type, you will ever pause

To think that, while you promise terror,

The greatest fear is yours.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Musa Okwonga
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Must purchase from author on his website at
https://okwonga.bigcartel.com/product/eating-roses-for-dinner-poems-by-musa-okwonga-2006-2015

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